

What else to watch: *The Maltese Falcon* (1941, p.331) ■ *The Big Sleep* (1946) ■ *Kiss Me Deadly* (1955, p.134) ■ *Vertigo* (1958, pp.140–45) ■ *The Postman Always Rings Twice* (1981) ■ *L.A. Confidential* (1997)



Gittes has his nose slashed as he gets too near the truth about the plot to dump water from the LA reservoirs. He is warned that if he continues to snoop, his whole nose will come off.

the hiring of Polanski, renowned for the psychological thrillers *Repulsion* (1965) and *Rosemary's Baby* (1968). Polanski was in Europe at the time, having left the US after the murder of his wife in 1969. He was tempted back by the strength of Towne's script, although Polanski and Towne had many differences over the final version.

There were two elements in particular that Polanski changed. First was the tragic and disturbing ending. Second was the decision not to use the voice-over narrative that so many private-eye film-noirs had employed in the past. Polanski insisted on letting the audience discover each new twist as Jake Gittes does. The effect of this is that both Jake and the audience are much more in the dark and far more unsettled by each new revelation.

Incompetent sleuth

Gittes' desperate attempt to make sense of everything makes him a different kind of private eye from Humphrey Bogart's Philip Marlowe a generation earlier in hard-boiled

detective movies such as *The Maltese Falcon*. The audience knows that Marlowe will triumph in the end, but it becomes apparent that Gittes is going to mess up again and again, as he jumps to all

the wrong conclusions. At the start of the movie, for instance, he is commissioned by the wife of Hollis Mulwray to prove her husband's adultery. Very quickly Gittes hands her the seemingly incriminating photos—only he's got it wrong twice over. First, the woman who commissioned him is not Mulwray's wife but an impostor. Second, the young woman that he snaps out with Mulwray is not his mistress at all, as he, and we, the audience, will discover much later. Later in the movie, Gittes wrongly assumes that the real Evelyn Mulwray murdered her husband. »

Noir conventions overturned

Genre convention		Chinatown subversion
Female lead is typically a "femme fatale"	→	Evelyn is revealed to be a victim
Protagonist is a hard-boiled private investigator	→	Gittes is incompetent, missing clues and making mistakes
Antagonist gets punished	→	Noah Cross escapes to continue his crimes
Protagonist succeeds in resolving crime or issue	→	Gittes leaves town after failing
Narrative closure	→	No resolution